

àW_@Ú`... - AOZ{dfX`J: Chapter 1 – Arjuna's Distress

‘ “b ûcH\$:

> Xd Zman¶U ZEdm gdXnf{dd{OV ‘ &
n[anU Jê\$íMmZ JrVWm dú¶{ ‘ bfV... &&

Benedictory Verse (Gita Bhashya) : Salutations to the Lord and teacher Narayana (Vedavyasa) who is revealed by the **Gita**. He is ever devoid of defects such as dependence and ignorance. He is not limited by time, space, and attributes. (Even though the **Gita** is full of many meanings, only a simple meaning is told here to aid general readers).

> लक्ष्मीZman¶U ZEdm nU^mYmZ Jê\$Z{n &
H\$_... I rH\$îUJrV¶m ^mî`mÚ°mWgJh_ &&

Benedictory Verse (Gita Vivruti) : After saluting Lord Narayana (consort of Lakshmi), Sri Madhwacharya, and other teachers, we are summarizing the concepts from **Gita Bhashya**, **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya** and related commentaries which offer a unique perspective on the **Bhagavad Gita** taught by Lord Sri Krishna.

Chapter Introduction: Sri Vedavyasa composed the great epic **Mahabharata** which contains all the essential teachings from the **Vedas**, and this allows even those who do not have access or eligibility to learn the **Vedas** to gain necessary knowledge to help them in their spiritual journey. The epic **Mahabharata** is spread over 18 volumes and the **Bhagavad Gita** (or **Gita**, in short), is part of *Bheeshma Parva* (or the Book of Bheeshma). The **Mahabharata** is compared to the divine flower *parijata*, and the **Gita** is like the nectar (or essence) of the flower. Sri Raghavendra Teertha (Sri Rayaru) has composed a unique commentary on the **Gita** titled, **Gita Vivruti** [GV] which is a summary of the two commentaries on the **Gita** by

Sri Madhwacharya namely, **Gita Bhashya** [GB] and **Gita Tatparya Nirnaya** [GTN]. The **Gita** has 701 verses spread over 18 chapters. Sri Rayaru has organized these 18 chapters into 3 sections of 6 chapters each. The first section (chapters 1-6) broadly describes the processes and prerequisites required to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge that one would need in one's spiritual journey. The second section (chapters 7-12) describes the nature of the divine, spiritual knowledge and the third section (chapters 13-18) expands on some of the key concepts covered in sections 1 and 2.

The Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Arjuna, and Lord Krishna as narrated by Lord Vedavyasa in the epic, **Mahabharata**. The great war between the armies of the Kaurava and Pandava cousins, was witnessed by Sanjaya, the aide of the blind King Dhrutarashtra who was head of the Kaurava dynasty. Sanjaya rushes to Dhrutarashtra soon after the fall of Bheeshma, the commander of the Kaurava army [**Mahabharata**, Bheeshma Parva, Chapter 13]. The stunned Dhrutarashtra wants to know everything that happened on the battlefield from the very beginning. Sanjaya narrates all the events from the beginning of the war. He stays with the king till the end of the war relaying all the events to him. He can do this because Sage Vedavyasa grants him divine vision to remotely view the war and provide him with updates.

All 47 verses in the first chapter and the first 10 verses in the second chapter provide the background and context for Arjuna's apprehensions about the war, and Lord Krishna starts His sermon to Arjuna then onwards.

Dhrutarashtra starts by asking the following question to Sanjaya.

What did my Clan and the Pandavas do in Kurukshetra?

YVamĩ CdMĩ -

Y_j ì H\$é j ì g_dVm ` ` Ēgd... &

_m_H\$m... nmÉSdmüd {H\$_H\$dV gÄO` ĩ&& 1 &&

Dhrutarashtra said: O Sanjaya! Assembled at Kuru Kshetra, the designated land for committing righteous acts (Field of Righteousness), what did my clan of Kauravas and Pandavas do? (1.1)

Comments: The first verse in the **Gita** starts with King Dhrutarashtra asking the above question to his aide Sanjaya. The first word here is ‘*Dharma*’ which is one of the names of the Lord Almighty who shoulders (*dharana*) the universe. In that sense, the first verse also acts as a benedictory verse of the **Gita**.

The King begins by asking Sanjaya what happened between his clan (Kauravas) and the Pandavas in Kurukshetra which was known as *Dharma Kshetra* or the ‘Field of Righteousness’. This question reveals the King’s apprehensions. He was convinced that the Pandavas with the guidance of Lord Krishna would be invincible (but Krishna had sworn not to take up arms). On the other hand, Bheeshma was also known to be invincible and so the King hoped against hope that his sons would not be defeated in this war that was being fought in an area known as the ‘Field of Righteousness’. Hence, he was surprised to hear that Bheeshma had fallen.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha Swamiji in his work **Bhagavad Gita Saroddhara** [BGS] identifies this verse as the central piece of chapter 1. After all, chapter 1 sets the context for the entire **Gita**, and it starts with King Dhrutarashtra’s question. The theatre of war is our body, and the armies represent the angelic and demoniac forces inside each of us. The interaction between them is the context for the **Gita**.

Duryodhana’s Apprehension

gO`CdM Ĩ-

ŃîQmV nġÊSdmZrH\$ ì`T> X`mYZñVXm Ĩ&

AmMm_ngJâ` amOm dMZ_~drV Ĩ&& 2 Ĩ&&

Sanjaya said: King Duryodhana, upon seeing the formation of the Pandavas' army, immediately rushed to his teacher Drona, and said as follows. (1.2)

Comments: Sanjaya answers Dhrutarashtra's question in the following 9 verses. Sri Sumateendra Teertha in his **Bhava Ratna Kosha** [BRK] draws attention to the use of the word 'tu' as implying Duryodhana's anxiety as soon as he saw the formidable Pandava army ('tu' is normally used to add emphasis). Hence, the Kaurava prince immediately rushes to his teacher Drona. It is interesting to note that Duryodhana approaches his teacher Drona and not the commander of the Kaurava forces, Bheeshma, to give him information about the Pandava army, perhaps to acknowledge the fact that many warriors in the Pandava army were Drona's students.

ní`Vm nmÊÊnîmUm\_mMm`_hVt M__Y&
ì`Tm ÐnXnìU Vd {eî`U Yr_Vm Y&& 3 Y&&

O My Teacher! Look at the formation of the mighty army of Pandavas which has been organized by your clever student Dhrushtadyumna, son of Drupada. (1.3)

Comments: Duryodhana reminds Drona that the formation of the Pandava army has been organized by Dhrushtadyumna, a brilliant warrior who learnt the art of warfare from Drona himself, implying that the Pandavas have a formidable army formation. Duryodhana also refers to the Pandavas' army as mighty, even though his own army was much bigger.

Aì eam_hîdmgm^r_mOZg_m`{Y Y&
`YmZm {damQü ÐnXü_hmaW... Y&& 4 Y&&

YîH\$Vü{H\$VmZ... H\$m{eamOü dr`dmZ Y&
né{OV H\$pvV^mOü eã`ü Zan`d... Y&& 5 &&

`Ym\_Ý`ü {dH\$nyV CÎm_mOmü dr`dmZ Ý&
gm^Ðm ÐmnX`mü gd Ed_hmaWm... Ý&& 6 &&

Possessing heavy weapons are the brave warriors Yuyudhana (Satyaki), Virata, and King Drupada, all *Maharathas*. They are as capable as Bheema and Arjuna. (1.4)

Other brave warriors include Drushtaketu, Chekitana, Kashiraja who are extraordinarily strong, Purujit, Kuntibhoja and Shybhya who are superior among men. (1.5)

Yudhamanyu, the brave warrior, Uttamowja, the strong warrior, Abhimanyu, son of Subhadra, and sons of Draupadi are also here. They too are *Maharathas*. (1.6)

Comments: Duryodhana recognizes and names 18 leaders from the Pandava army whom he considers as being comparable to Bheema and Arjuna in valor. They are – Dhrushtadyumna, Satyaki, Virata, Drupada, Drushtaketu, Chekitana, Kashiraja, Purujit, Kuntibhoja, Shybhya, Yudhamanyu, Uttamowja, Abhimanyu and the five sons of Draupadi (Parativindya, Sutasoma, Shrutakeerti, Shataneeka, Shrutakarma). These leaders were termed '*Maharathas*', meaning they were capable of single-handedly fighting 10,000 enemy soldiers. They were experts in the use of both types of weapons – *astra* and *shastra*. Here, *astra* refers to weapons such as arrows that are launched after praying and invoking a deity, and *shastra* refers to arrows that are launched without such invocation.

Interestingly, Duryodhana does not name Krishna who was charioteering Arjuna. This is perhaps due to Krishna's vow that He would not take up arms in the war. Duryodhana probably thought Krishna did not count if He was not fighting. A big miscalculation!

Añ_mH\$ V {d{eî'm ` VmZ {Z~mY {ÔOmîm_ ÿ&
Zm`H\$m \_\_ gÝ`ñ` gÄkmW VmZ ~dr{ V ÿ&& 7 &&

^dmZ ^rî_ü H\$Uü H\$nü g{qVÄO`... &
AœEWm_m {dH\$Uü gm_X{ÎmñVWd M ÿ&& 8 &&

AÝ` M ~hd... eam 'XW Ë`°\$Or{dVm... ÿ&
ZmZmeóàhaUm... gd `Õ{demaXm... ÿ&& 9 &&

O Drona! Superior among the wise men! Now I will enumerate the great warriors from our side. So, please listen with attention (1.7)

Our side includes yourself, Bheeshma, Karna, Krupa who has won many wars, Ashwatthama, Vikarna and Bhoorishravas, son of Somadatta. (1.8)

Along with them are many warriors ready to sacrifice their lives for my sake. They are all well versed in wars and are armed with heavy weapons. (1.9)

Comments: Duryodhana now names 7 leaders from his side. He indicates that they are all ready to sacrifice their lives for him. Duryodhana is looking at this war purely to justify holding onto the Pandavas' share of the kingdom and believes that everyone in his side is fighting to please him and not for any higher cause. It is interesting to note that while Duryodhana names 18 leaders from the Pandavas, he only rattles 7 names from his side. Further he does not name his brothers such as Dushasana. This points to some doubts in his mind about his brothers' capabilities.

An`má VXñ_mH\$ ~b ^rî_m{^a{j V_ ÿ&
n`má pĕdX_Vfm ~b ^r_m{^a{j V_ && 10 &&

But our army headed by Bheeshma is not strong enough to defeat them. While their army headed by Bheema can defeat us. (1.10)

Comments: After reviewing the two armies, Duryodhana is beginning to have doubts about the capabilities of his army. He knows that his is not a just cause, but as a representation of *Kali*, the evil soul, it is in his nature to adamantly get into a war even when he knows that he is wrong and that his side is not capable of winning. Note that while Dhrushtadyumna is the commander of the Pandavas' army, Duryodhana recognizes that the real leader of the Pandavas is the hugely experienced Bheema.

A`Zf M gdf `Wm^mJ_dpñWVm... Ý&
^rî__dm{^aj ÝV ^dÝV... gd Ed {h Ý&& 11 &&

Hence all of you need to position yourselves in your designated spots in the formations and guard Bheeshma, our commander. (1.11)

Comments: Duryodhana is very particular about protecting Bheeshma as he is worried that Bheeshma's fall would discourage his entire army. The fact that he was worried about the safety of Bheeshma who was the most capable warrior in his side is an indication of his fear.

Bugle Calls

Vñ` gOZ`Z hf H\$édÕ... {nVm_h... Ý&
qghZmX {dZÚm f ... e l XÜ_m àVmndmZ Ý&& 12 &&

To inject confidence in Duryodhana, the very courageous Bheeshma who is the senior most Kaurava, roared like a lion and sounded his conch. (1.12)

Comments: Bheeshma recognizes that Duryodhana is so petrified looking at the strength of the Pandava army that he asks Drona and others to protect him. In fact, it is the duty of Bheeshma, as the commander, to protect the Kaurava army. To instill confidence in Duryodhana and the

other Kauravas, Bheeshma signals his readiness by his lion like roar and the sounding of his conch.

VV... e I mü ^` ü nUdmZH\$Jm _ I m... &
ghgdmä`hý`ýV g eãXñV _bm@^dV ý&& 13 &&

Conch-shells, bugles, trumpets, drums, and cow horns were sounded loudly by the Kauravas which resulted in their sound filling the entire space. (1.13)

Comments: Taking a cue from Bheeshma, other Kaurava leaders sounded various organs to signal their readiness and command their troops to get ready. It is interesting to note that while Bheeshma sounds his conch, a musical instrument with spiritual significance which has a pleasant sound, other leaders sound different instruments, many making harsh sounds not in harmony with each other. Perhaps an indication of disharmony and disunity among the Kauravas.

VV... æVh` `°\$ _h{V ñ`ýXZ pñWVm ý&
_mYd... nmÊSdüd {Xì`m eL I m àXÜ _V... && 14 &&

At this time, Lord Madhava (Krishna) and Arjuna, son of Pandu, who were seated on a magnificent chariot pulled by white horses, sounded their respective divine conch shells. (1.14)

Comments: Lord Krishna and Arjuna sounding their conches while seated in a horse drawn chariot also has a spiritual interpretation. As noted by Sri Vidyamanya Teertha in his GPM, as per the **Upanishads**, the chariot is a representation of the human body. The wandering horses represent the sense organs, and the road travelled represents the objects of sense pleasure. The charioteer (Krishna) represents the intellect, and the leash which controls the horses represents the mind. The charioteer (Krishna) and the passenger (Arjuna) respectively represent the Supreme Soul and the individual soul resident in each body. The conch is shaped like the

primordial symbol ‘Om’ which is the root letter of all scriptures. Hence the conversation between Krishna and Arjuna represents the collective wisdom of scriptures such as the **Vedas**.

n#mOY` öfrH\$em XdXÎm YZÄO`...Y&
nmÊS XU_m_hme I | ^r_H\$_m dH\$mXa...Y&& 15 &&

AZYV{dO` amOm H\$YVrnÎm `{Y{ða...Y&
ZH\$b...ghXdü gKnf_{UnîH\$m Y&& 16 &&

H\$mí`ü na_îdmg...{e I ÊSr M_hmaW...Y&
YiÜâZm {damQü gmÊ`{H\$ümnam{OV...Y&& 17 &&

ÐnXm ÐmnX`mü gde...n{WdrnV Y&
gm^Ðü _hm~mh...e I XU_...nWH\$ nWH Y&&18 &&

Lord Hrishikesha (Krishna) sounded Panchajanya, Dhananjaya (Arjuna) sounded Devadatta, and valiant Vrukodara (Bheema) sounded Powndra. (1.15)

King Yudhishtira, son of Kunti, sounded Anantavijaya, and Nakula and Sahadeva sounded Sughosha and Manipushpaka, respectively. (1.16)

The King of Kashi an expert bowman, Shikhandi a great warrior on chariot, Dhrushtadyumna, Virata and Satyaki, unbeaten in a war, all sounded their respective conch shells. (1.17)

Likewise, King Drupada, the son of Draupadi and the strong-armed brave son of Subhadra (Abhimanyu,) all sounded their respective conch shells. (1.18)

Comments: It is interesting to note that while the Kauravas used various instruments to sound their readiness, the Pandavas uniformly sounded their respective conches to the maximum effect to display unity.

g Kmf YmVamimUm öX`n{Z ì`Xma`V ÿ&
Z^ü n{Wdt Md V_bm ì`ZZmX`Z ÿ&& 19 &&

The vibrations from the massive sound of the Pandava warriors' conch shells echoed across the earth and sky, spreading everywhere, and shattered the hearts of King Dhrutarashtra's sons. (1.19)

Comments: The massive, uniform sound from the synchronized sounding of conch shells by the Pandava leaders cut into the Kaurava hearts as if to warn them of their impending defeat and destruction.

AW ì`dmpñWVmZ XîQm YmVamimZ H\${nÜdO... ÿ&
àdîm eógânmV YZéÚâ` nmÊSd... ÿ&& 20 &&

öfrH\$e VXm dmŠ` ' BX_mh_hrnV ÿ&

Looking at King Dhrutarashtra's children who were ready to wage the war, Arjuna, (the one whose chariot bears the flag of Lord Hanuman), just when the time had come to operate the weapons, held up his bow, and spoke to Lord Krishna as follows. (1.20)

Comments: Arjuna wants to take a good look at the armies which consisted of all major, accomplished rulers and warriors of that time. In this verse, a reference is made to the flag of Arjuna's chariot which bears the figure of Lord Hanuman, the great warrior from the **Ramayana**. This indicates that both the Supreme Soul (*paramatma* = Lord Krishna) and the superior soul among all individual souls (*jeevottama* = *vayudeva* = Hanuman) are protecting Arjuna.

Arjuna Inspects the Armies

AOZ CdM -

gZ`mé^`_Ü` aW ñWmn`_@À`V && 21 &&

`mdXVnZ {Z[a j @h `mÖH\$m_mZdpñWVnZ &

H\$_m gh `mÖi` ' Apñ_Z aUg_Ú_ && 22 &&

`mËñ`_mZmZ Adj @h ` EV@ì g_mJVm... &

YmVamĩñ` X~Ö`Ö {à`{MH\$fd... && 23 &&

Arjuna said: O Achyuta! Please position my chariot in between the two armies. I would like to look at those who are assembled here, ready to fight the war, and with whom I will be fighting. (1.21) (1.22)

I would also like to look at those warriors who are here to fight the war to please the evil minded Duryodhana (son of Dhrutarashtra). (1.23)

Comments: After Duryodhana's review of the armies, it is the turn of Arjuna to survey the forces assembled on the battlefield. Arjuna's review and feelings of apprehension about waging the war form the basis for Sri Krishna's sermon (Gita).

gO` CdM &

Ed_°\$m öfrH\$em JSmH\$eZ ^maV &

gZ`mé^`_Ü` ñWmn{`Edm aWmÎm__ && 24 &&

^rî_ĐmUà_I V... gdfm M_hr{ j Vm_ &

CdM nmW ní`VmZ g `dVmZ H\$e\$Z{V && 25 &&

Sanjaya said: O Bhaarata! (Dhrutarashtra, from the lineage of King Bharata)! Lord Hrishikesha (Krishna), addressed thus by Gudakesha (Arjuna) positioned the grand chariot in between the two armies. (1.24)

Turning the chariot towards Bheeshma, Drona and other kings, Lord Krishna said - O Partha (Arjuna)! Look at all the Kauravas assembled here. (1.25)

Comments: Arjuna is referred to as Gudakesha – the one who has conquered sleep (*gudaka*). Sleep, along with lethargy represents *tamas* (ignorance). Sleep is probably the most difficult state for one to overcome. Thus, anyone who can control sleep is said to have control over sense organs. Hence, Arjuna is most eligible to receive the sermon from the Lord. The Lord is referred to as Hrishikesha, one who has control over everyone's sense organs and indeed on everyone and everything in the universe.

Vìmní`V pñWVmZ nmW... {nVZW {nVm_hmZ ý&
AmMm`mZ _mVbmZ ^mVZ nìmZ nmìmZ g l tñVWm ý&
æeamZ göXüd gZ`mé^`ma{n ý&& 26 &&

VmZ g_rú` g H\$mÝV`... gdmZ ~ÝYZdpñWVmZ ý&
H\$m`m na`m@{dïm {dfrX{pX_~drV ý&&27&&

Looking at both the armies, Arjuna sees warriors who were like his father (father figures), father-in-law, grandfathers, uncles, teachers, brothers, sons, grandsons, friends, and colleagues. (1.26)

Seeing all his relatives assembled there to wage the war, Arjuna (son of Kunti) was overwhelmed by emotion and addressed Sri Krishna with great anxiety. (1.27)

Comments: While Arjuna knew that many of his near and dear ones would be participating in the war, he is overwhelmed when he sees all of

them assembled in one place. Faced with the prospect of many of them dying, regardless of who won the war, Arjuna is overcome with grief and emotion.

Sri Rayaru in GV provides an explanation for the term *vishada* which is used to express Arjuna's emotion. *Vishada* means mental weakness caused by grief, which is a result of delusion, which in turn is caused by the fear of losing loved ones.

Arjuna Develops Cold Feet

AOZ CdmM V&
ÔîQ_ ñdOZ H\$îU ``Ëg g_npñWV_ V&& 28 &&

grXpÝV __ Jmîm{U _ I M n[aeî`{V V&
ddWü eara _ am_hfü Om`V V&& 29 &&

Arjuna said: O Krishna! I am looking at my relatives and friends gathered here to wage the war. (1.28)

Looking at them, my limbs are weakening, my face is crumpling, my body is trembling, and my hair is bristling. (1.29)

Comments: From this verse, till the end of this chapter is a description of Arjuna's anxiety and fear when faced with the prospect of waging the war which would result in the loss of lives of multitudes of people including many of his near and dear ones. Note that Arjuna begins describing his anxiety to the Lord by addressing Him as Krishna. This has a special significance. Sri Madhwacharya in his **Gita Bhashya** [GB] (5th Chapter), interprets Krishna as '*Lokarakshaka*', the one who controls everyone and everything in the universe. By using this term, Arjuna expresses his faith that Lord Krishna will have a solution to his grief.

JmÊSrd ògV hñVmV ĒdH\$ Md n[aXøV ĩ&
Z M eŠZmā`dñWmV ^_Vrd M _ _Z... ĩ&& 30 ĩ&&

{Z{Îm{Z M nÍ`m{ {dnarVm{Z H\$ed ĩ&
Z M I`m@ZnÍ`m{ hĒdm ñdOZ_mhd ĩ&& 31 &&

Z H\$m→ {dO` H\$îU Z M amÁ` g I m{Z M ĩ&
qH\$ Zm amÁ`Z Jm{dÝX qH\$ ^mJOu{dVZ dm ĩ&&32&&

My bow (Gandeeva) is slipping from my hands, my skin is burning, I am unable to even stand, and my mind is blurred with delusion. (1.30)

O Keshava! I am seeing many bad omens. I do not see anything good coming out of killing my own people. (1.31)

O Krishna! I do not aspire for victory, kingdom, or happiness. O! Govinda! What use is this kingdom, luxuries, or even living? (1.32)

Comments: Sri Madhwacharya in his Gita Bhashya [GB], interprets the Lord's name Keshava, as the one who inspires even deities Brahma (*ka*) and Rudra (*esha*). Arjuna, by using this term to address the Lord expresses his complete faith that Lord Krishna who inspires even deities Brahma and Rudra, can surely help him. Arjuna's sensing of bad omens reflects his weak mind (If these omens were indeed predicting bad outcomes, he would have lost the war, which did not happen).

`fm\_W H\$m{→V Zm amÁ` ^mJm... g I m{Z M ĩ&
V B_@dpñWVm `Õ àmUmñĒ`³Ēdm YZm{Z M ĩ&& 33 &&

AmMm`m... {nVa... nÎmñVWd M {nVm_hm... ĩ&
_mVbm... ídeam... nmÎm... í`mbm... gā~pÝYZñVWm ĩ&& 34 &&

EVmP hÝV{ ÀNm{ ¿ZVm@{n _YgXZ Ý&
A{n ÌbmŠ`amÁ`ñ` hVm... qH\$ Z _hrH\$V Ý&& 35&&

The very people for whom we work hard to provide comfort and luxury are here ready to give up their possessions and even their lives. They are like my father, grandfather, uncle, son, grandson, brother, brother-in-law, teacher, and other relatives. (1.33) (1.34)

O Madhusoodana! Even if they hurt me, I do not want to kill them. I would not kill them even if I could win all three worlds by doing so. Why would I kill them just for some land? (1.35)

Comments: Arjuna is overcome with emotion and states that even if his enemies attacked him when he turned away from war, he would not want to harm them. Even if victory would net him all the three worlds, he would not value them if he had to kill his loved ones. Why then would he wage a war just for some land?

Note that Arjuna addresses Krishna as Madhusoodana. Demons Madhu and Kaitabha were born out of Krishna's sweat and in that sense are Krishna's children. As they grew up, they became very evil, and Krishna had no choice but to destroy them. Arjuna indicates here that he does not have such strong will power.

{ZhÈ` YmVamimZ Z... H\$m àr{V... ñ`m, mZmXZ Ý&
nmn_dm@ I`Xñ\_mZ hĒdVmZ AmVWm{`Z... Ý&& 36 &&

Vñ_mPmhm d` hÝV YmVamimZ g~mÝYdmZ Ý&
ñdOZ {h H\$W hĒdm g{ I Z... ñ`m _mYd Ý&& 37&&

O Janardana! What pleasure do we get by killing the sons of Dhrutarashtra? Killing these vandals (*atatayins*) will only result in accumulation of sins. (1.36)

O Madhava! It is not proper for us to kill Dhrutarashtra's sons who are our own relatives. How can we achieve happiness by killing our own people? (1.37)

Comments: Arjuna refers to the Kauravas as *atatayina* which means those who have committed one or more of the following six sins – torching others, poisoning others, using weapons against the unprotected, stealing others' land, money, and women. It is the duty of someone in Arjuna's position to destroy those who commit these sins. It is his duty to preserve and protect the innocent in society. While Arjuna is aware that the Kauravas deserve to be punished, he is worried that doing so would result in collateral damage – that is the death of his relatives, elders and teachers which would result in him accumulating sins.

Arjuna Argues Against War

¶Úß`V Z ní`pÝV b^{m^}mnhVMVg... Ý&
H\$b j`H\$V Xmf { _ÎÐmh M nmVH\$_ Ý&& 38 &&

H\$W Z k`_ñ_m{^... nmnXñ_m{pd{VW_ Ý&
H\$b j`H\$V Xmf àní`{ØOZmXZ Ý&& 39 &&

H\$b j`àUí`pÝV H\$bY_m... gZmVZm... Ý&
Y_Zi`H\$b H\$EñZ\_ AY\_m@{^^dE`V Ý&& 40 &&

AY_m{^^dmV H\$îU àXî`pÝV H\$b{ó`... Ý&
órf Xîng dîU` Om`V dUgLH\$a... Ý&& 41 &&

gLH\$a_m ZaH\$m`d H\$b;ZmZm H\$bñ` M Ý&
nVpÝV {nVam øfm bá{nÊSmXH\${H\$`m... Ý&& 42 &&

These Kauravas who are greedy for the kingdom have no knowledge of the sins they would accumulate by killing their family members and by betraying their friends. (1.38)

O Janardana! How can we, who understand the perils of destroying families, not be aware of the need to stay away from these sinful acts? (1.39)

With the destruction of the families, traditional familial virtues will perish. When virtuousness declines, unrighteousness will permeate society. (1.40)

O Vaarshneya! The rise of unrighteousness will cause surviving women to stray away from morality. Women devoid of morals result in unholy families. (1.41)

Rise of unholy families will push the lineage of children and grandchildren to hell and departed elders who are deprived of appropriate offerings will also fall into hell. (1.42)

Comments: Arjuna tries to make a case for avoiding the battle by putting forward additional arguments. His initial argument was that the war would result in the loss of many innocent lives, including elders and teachers who were pious and revered. Here he argues that the loss of many men in the war would lead to instability in society and give rise to unholy families. This would result in the loss of compulsory rituals such as offerings to departed elders. Arjuna also says that the Kauravas are blinded by their greed and are unable to see the perils of such a war. But how could the Pandavas who are a lot more knowledgeable about such perils be similarly blinded?

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Such sinful deeds by destroyers of families will result in corruption of virtuous classes and decline of virtuous familial traditions. (1.43)

O Janardana! We have heard from elders that people whose virtuous familial traditions are destroyed are sure to fall into hell. (1.44)

Alas! We are about to commit a great sin by killing our own people because of our greed for kingdom and for the sake of happiness. (1.45)

It would be better for me if I relinquished my weapons and offered no resistance while Dhrutarashtra's sons kill me in this war. (1.46)

Comments: Arjuna now summarizes his arguments for staying away from the war. Firstly, he would be committing a great sin by killing near and dear ones which included elders and teachers who were pious and revered. Secondly, the loss of millions of men would lead to instability in society due to straying away from traditions related to a class (*jati dharma*) and traditions specific to families (*kula dharma*). In addition, anyone causing these would accrue sins to their departed elders. Arjuna laments that he is about to commit great sins in waging this war, the purpose of which is to gain the kingdom. He is convinced that it is better for him to relinquish his weapons and let the Kauravas kill him as that would prevent him from accruing sins and in fact may lead him to heavens hereafter for his noble act.

As will be seen later, Arjuna fights the war and the Pandavas successfully rule their kingdom for many years. None of Arjuna's fears come true. The evil clan of the Kauravas and their supporters such as the virtuous but guilty Bheeshma and Drona are vanquished, and society does not fall apart. In fact, Bharat enjoys a long, peaceful and prosperous period under Pandavas' rule. The **Gita** clearly suggests that omens do not have any predictive value and chastise superstitious practices. Arjuna's experience of bad omens reflect his weak mental condition which is caused by his excessive attachment to his near and dear ones.

Arjuna Drops His Weapons

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Sanjaya said: Having said thus, Arjuna, stricken with deep sorrow in his mind, drops his bow and arrows and sits still in the middle of his chariot. (1.47)

Comments: While Arjuna indicates to Krishna his anxiety and unwillingness to wage war, his relinquishing of his bow and arrows is a signal to his large army that he is not yet ready to start the war. (The army of course could not have heard the conversation between Arjuna and Krishna). This action has led to their enemies drawing their own conclusions which Krishna indicates later.

Summary of Chapter 1

The Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Arjuna and Lord Krishna as narrated by Lord Vedavyasa in the epic, **Mahabharata**. The great war between the armies of the Kaurava and the Pandava cousins, was witnessed by Sanjaya, aide of the blind King Dhrutarashtra who was head of the Kaurava dynasty. Sanjaya rushes to Dhrutarashtra soon after the fall

of Bheeshma, the commander of the Kaurava army. The stunned Dhrutarashtra wants to know everything that happened on the battlefield from the very beginning. Sanjaya narrates all the events from the beginning of the war. He stays with the king till the end of the war relaying all the events to him. He can do this because Sage Vedavyasa grants him divine vision to view the war remotely and provide Dhrutarashtra the updates.

The King starts by asking Sanjaya as to what happened between his clan (the Kauravas) and the Pandavas in Kurukshetra (which is known as Dharma Kshetra or the 'Field of Righteousness') (1.1). This question reveals the King's apprehensions. He is convinced that the Pandavas with the guidance of Lord Krishna would be invincible (but, Krishna has sworn not to touch or take up arms). On the other hand, Bheeshma, the very epitome of justice, was also known to be invincible. The King was therefore hoping against hope that his sons would not be defeated, especially in a war that was being fought in an area known as the Field of Righteousness. So, he was shocked to hear that Bheeshma had fallen. Sanjaya responds, saying that initially Duryodhana looks at the Pandava army and rushes to inform his teacher Dronacharya about its strength. He makes sure to let him know that the army is being led by Dhrishtadyumna, a student of Drona himself. Then he goes on to enumerate other great leaders on the side of the Pandavas. These leaders were termed '*Maharathas*', meaning they were capable of single-handed fighting with 10,000 enemy soldiers. In all, Duryodhana enumerates 18 leaders from the Pandavas' side, other than the five Pandava brothers. Interestingly, he does not recognize Krishna as being a part of the Pandava side. This is because Krishna had vowed not to use any arms in the war. Duryodhana obviously did not realize the invaluable advice and guidance that Krishna would be providing to Arjuna. Ultimately, this miscalculation had led to the Kauravas' defeat. This illustrates the peril of ignoring the Lord who is responsible for everything in this universe, just because one cannot physically see Him. (1.2-1.6). Duryodhana then enumerates the great warriors on his side which included – Dronacharya, Bheeshma, Karna, Krupa, Ashwatthama, Vikarna and Bhoorishravas. However, he did not expect the Pandavas to turn up with a huge, well-organized army. He

knows that in addition to the experienced warriors, the Pandava army also included the 5 young children of Draupadi and each of them was brave and capable. He also knows that while Dhrushtadyumna is the commander of the Pandava army, it is really the invincible Bheema who is their star warrior. Duryodhana is now clearly very perturbed. He wants to ensure that Bheeshma is well protected as he sees Bheeshma as extremely critical to his victory. He asks Dronacharya and others to ensure Bheeshma's safety (1.7-1.11). At this time, sensing Duryodhana's worry, Bheeshma decided to instil confidence in him by loudly roaring like a lion and sounding his conch. Other soldiers in the Kaurava army follow by sounding drums, trumpets, bugles etc, and the collective sound seemed to envelope the entire space. Now it is the turn of the Pandavas. Sri Krishna and Arjuna, while seated in their chariots sound their respective conches followed by other leaders in their army. The collective sound of these conches reverberated across earth and sky and seemed to shatter the hearts of King Dhrutarashtra's sons. It is interesting to note that while the Kauravas used various instruments to sound their readiness, the Pandavas uniformly sounded their respective conches for the maximum effect. Lord Krishna and Arjuna sounding their conches while seated in a horse drawn chariot also has a spiritual interpretation. The chariot is a representation of the human body as noted in the **Upanishads**. The horses which pull the chariot represent the sense organs, and the roads travelled represent objects of sense pleasure. The charioteer (Krishna) represents the intellect, and the leash which controls the horses represents the mind. The charioteer (Krishna) and the passenger (Arjuna) represent the Supreme soul and the individual soul resident in each body. The conch is shaped like the primordial symbol 'Om' which is the root letter of all scriptures. Hence the conversation between Krishna and Arjuna represents the collective wisdom of all the scriptures such as the **Vedas** (1.12-1.19). Arjuna requests Krishna to take the chariot to the middle of the battleground so that he can have a good look at both the armies. He recognizes his teachers, cousins, nephews, uncles, grand uncles, children, friends etc., and gets very depressed. He is distressed at the very thought of waging a war where he himself might kill many of his near and dear ones. Arjuna tells Krishna that his body is

trembling, and that he is unable to hold his weapons. He was feeling disoriented and disillusioned. He was further seeing bad omens and felt there was nothing good coming out of this war. He says he does not crave for victory, or a kingdom won after losing so many near and dear ones (1.20-1.39). He reasons that with massive destruction of men, familial values would perish, and unrighteousness would take over society. Arjuna says that such a war has no benefits either here or hereafter. He says he would rather drop his weapons and let the Kauravas kill him rather than be responsible for such a destructive war. Saying thus, Arjuna drops his weapon to the ground and sits in his chariot feeling extremely dejected (1.40-1.47).

The rest of the **Gita** is a sermon from Lord Krishna to Arjuna to help him overcome his distress and doubts. The dropping of weapons by Arjuna is equivalent to one abdicating one's responsibility. At this stage, the following points are worth noting: Duryodhana was also distressed after looking at the Pandavas' army but there is a big difference between the distress of Duryodhana and that of Arjuna. Duryodhana was distressed at the thought of not being able to win the war and thereby usurp the Pandavas share of the kingdom illegally. On the other hand, Arjuna's distress was out of compassion towards his loved ones. Duryodhana shows no such compassion. Arjuna was not afraid of fighting as he had fought many wars before and had won them. But this time it was different. His enemies were people he cared for dearly.

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End of Chapter 1